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CINEMA

MADE IN HEAVEN

Premiering at the Toronto International Film Festival, Jayant Digambar Somalkar's first Marathi feature film, *Sthal*, examines the fraught dynamics of arranged marriages

When Jayant Digambar Somalkar received a confirmation email from the Toronto International Film Festival, he thought it was a joke. "I could not believe it. I remember checking if it was fake. I was very happy," he says. His Marathi feature *Sthal* (A Match) has been selected to premiere at the festival's Discovery Programme, a section devoted to showcasing the work of emerging filmmakers from across the globe. That it is the only Indian film to make this cut elevates the prestige of the inclusion.

It's not his first work, of course. Last year, Somalkar co-wrote and co-directed the Amazon Prime show *Guilty Minds* with Shefali Bhushan. But *Sthal*, he maintains, is a passion project. The intimate feature centres on arranged marriages in India, underlining the dispensable way women are treated. Somalkar uses the premise to make a pointed commentary on the stilted definition of beauty, the lack of women's agency, and the wide gap that exists between education and an educator.

Sthal revolves around a young girl called Savita, a third-year BA student in Dongargaon, Maharashtra, whose desire for higher education is in conflict with her family's persistent quest to get her married. Somalkar does not villainise them. In a country like India where women are often treated as a liability and their achievements are measured in terms of who they are married to, this is not an exception. Savita's father is a cotton farmer, his limited resources accentuating the need to get his daughter married and relieve himself of the 'load'. *Sthal* unfolds with repetitions—people coming to see Savita, huddling up to discuss her and commenting on her skin-tone among themselves—foregrounding the inhuman treatment women are subjected to in pursuit of an arranged match.

Somalkar's treatment is fuss-free. No point is over-stressed, no gesture is exaggerated. "I wanted to make a realistic and authentic film," admits Somalkar, who has set the story in his native village. The actors were chosen from the region; none of them had faced a camera before. They converse in Varhadi, a regional dialect of Marathi. The house shown in the first scene is where he was born. His mother, friends, sister-in-law and Somalkar himself make an appearance.

The filmmaker has created a world he is familiar with. "I have two elder sisters and I have seen the process." But back then, he was a child. The idea of writing something like this was triggered when he accompanied a cousin to see a prospective bride a couple of years back. "I was sitting there with the rest and that is when it hit me." The result was a first draft he wrote in 2015, and now, a full-length feature film premiering at one of the most prestigious film festivals in the world. ■

Ishita Sengupta